could the besotted commander do? ‘No one can force the affections of the heart,’ writes Badauni, wisely. Ali Quli surrendered his wife to his lover.

Meanwhile, Akbar had decided to drown Ali Quli’s passion in work – an order arrived for the warlord to leave Lucknow and go conquer Jaunpur. Ali Quli obeyed; when he went to Jaunpur, he even sent Shahim Beg away, though not without another poem – ‘The [cold] wind of absence knows no bounds.’ Shahim Beg was to leave, Aram Jaan in tow, and lie low a while in Sarharpur, a fiefdom not too far from Jaunpur. Ali Quli hoped they would be reunited once the ‘wrath of the Emperor . . . abated’.[65]

Ali Quli might have thought he had it all figured out, but he hadn’t taken his lover’s fickle heart into account. Shahim Beg did go to Sarharpur, but once there he appears to have surrendered both his affection and Aram Jaan to its fief-holder, Abdur Rahman – then demanded her back. When Abdur Rahman refused, Shahim Beg tied him up and ran off with Aram Jaan. They were dallying in amorous if strategically unwise solitude when they were interrupted by Abdur Rahman’s brother, who arrived with a posse of armed men, one of whom killed the faithless knight.

Abdur Rahman hurried to Akbar’s court, hoping to present the whole affair as ‘good service’[66] – his own bright idea, that is, to rid the world of Shahim Beg’s intoxicating influence. Ali Quli’s love, meanwhile, had wilted not a jot from Shahim’s faithless behaviour. He was in mourning, and galloping on Abdur Rahman’s heels, having hot words, at the very least, to exchange with the man who murdered his philandering lover. But when it became clear that Abdur Rahman would reach Akbar before Ali Quli caught him, the heartbroken warrior reined in his horse and returned to Jaunpur. Here, he buried the undeserving Shahim Beg by the side of a lake, and built a grand tomb for the man who stole his heart. ‘Night put on mourning black, and Morn / Raised a cold sigh, and rent its dress,’ writes Badauni. Abul Fazl wastes no time on condoling verses; for him, this was only another example of how resistance to Akbar invited a bad end.

Thus, the ‘insane affair’[67] was ended, though neither man tells us what happened to Aram Jaan – that ‘street-walker’, Abul Fazl hisses, ‘that wanton [woman]’. In what may be a painting of the brawl that claimed Shahim Beg’s life, we may imagine her not overly perturbed by the commotion of armed men around her, nor by the spreadeagled form of her